



Unit 2: Running a Relay Race

These girls are waiting for the starting pistol to fire. They are all in the set position with a baton in hand. If no one jumps the gun, they will be off immediately after the starting pistol fires. In the event of a false start, they will have to line up again and the person responsible will be penalized. If any runner is responsible for two false starts, they will be disqualified.

The lanes are marked off with parallel white lines that circle the entire track. A white line is also used across each lane to mark the starting lines. They are staggered around the bend because it is actually further to run in the outside lane if they were all to start across from each other. It makes each lane the same distance from the finish line, so that there is no advantage to being in any of the lanes.

The girls wait for the starting official to say “On your mark, get set, go”; at which point the official fires the pistol. Assuming there are no false starts, the athletes will run as fast as they can and then hand off the baton to the person designated to run the second leg of the race. They must be careful during this process, as there is only a short distance to make the handoff. A smooth transition is crucial and could win you the race. A sloppy handoff could mean the difference between first and second. Dropping the baton, on the other hand, not only wastes precious time, but could also cost you the race.

There are 4 legs in a relay race. The last runner is called the anchor and is often the fastest runner, but this isn't always the case as some teams may have different strategies. Regardless of who has the fastest runner, it all comes down to good teamwork and executing good handoffs. You can have the fastest man in the world on



your team and still lose if you drop the baton. Again, it's all about teamwork and the team that crosses the finish line first is the winner.